

ATLANTA NORTH VESPERS

Demas and the Drift

When Good Work Replaces First Love

2 Timothy 4:10

Chukwuma Onyeije · Atlanta North Vespers

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F — NOTES

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FACILITATOR ANCHOR — KEEP THIS IN VIEW ALL EVENING

*"Before Demas left the path,
his heart had already begun to drift."*

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F — NOTES

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Right now, what gets most of your daily attention?

A

Christ and devotional life

B

Career and professional growth

C

Relationships and family

D

Personal goals and self-development

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F — NOTES



*"Which of these could slowly replace Christ —
without you even noticing?"*

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F — NOTES



SCRIPTURE

The Three Mentions of Demas

The arc is the whole point.

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F — NOTES

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COLOSSIANS 4:14

*"Luke the beloved physician, and Demas,
greet you."*

The co-laborer. Present. Trusted. Named.

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F — NOTES

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PHILEMON 1:24

*"Marcus, Aristarchus, Demas, Lucas,
my fellow labourers."*

Still in the inner circle. Still working.

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F — NOTES

2 of 3



2 TIMOTHY 4:10

*"For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved
this present world."*

Paul doesn't say Demas became wicked. He says Demas loved something else more.

Ask someone to read passages from Ellen G. White on Demas.

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F — NOTES

3 of 3



Did Demas fall suddenly — or drift gradually?

"What do you think happened between Colossians and 2 Timothy?"

Turn to one person near you. Two minutes. Then we share back.

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F — NOTES



"Demas was not lost in a day.

He was lost by degrees."

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F — NOTES



What do you think is the primary diagnosis for Demas?

A

Burnout and spiritual exhaustion

B

Gradual distraction by success

C

Loss of devotional discipline

D

Misplaced love — loving a good thing too much

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ELLEN WHITE · TESTIMONIES FOR THE CHURCH, VOL. 5, P. 161

“Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer, no time for the study of the Bible... The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity.”

— Ellen G. White

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F — NOTES



THE CORE TENSION

Good Work vs. First Love

Both truths are real. The tension is the point.

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F — NOTES



HOLD BOTH OF THESE AT THE SAME TIME

God calls us to meaningful work in the world.

The world can quietly replace God in our hearts.

The tension between them is not a contradiction. It is the permanent condition of the Christian life.

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F — NOTES



ELLEN WHITE · THE GREAT CONTROVERSY, P. 508

“*Satan works to distort the character of God — often making Him seem harsh or unloving — to distract humans, breaking their focus and preventing a close, personal relationship with Him.*”

— Ellen G. White

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F — NOTES

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SMALL GROUPS — 3 TO 4 PEOPLE — 4 MINUTES

Two questions for your group:

“How do you know when your work is still worship — and when it has become replacement?”

“What does loving Christ practically look like in a busy professional life?”

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F — NOTES

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*"If the final crisis is about worship and allegiance —
not activity — then Demas is not a cautionary tale
about slacking off.*

*He is a cautionary tale about
what we worship while we work."*

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F — NOTES

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ELLEN WHITE · STEPS TO CHRIST, P. 44

“*It is not so much the fear of punishment, or the hope of everlasting reward, that leads the disciples of Christ to follow Him. They behold the Saviour's matchless love... and to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure.*”

— Ellen G. White

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F — NOTES

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BIBLICAL REORIENTATION

Christ at the Center

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F — NOTES



MATTHEW 6:21

*"For where your treasure is,
there will your heart be also."*

The heart follows what you value. The treasure reveals what you love.

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F — NOTES



REVELATION 2:4 — TO THE CHURCH AT EPHESUS

*"Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee,
because thou hast left thy first love."*

A church that worked harder than any other. But the heart had moved.

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F — NOTES

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ELLEN WHITE · THE ACTS OF THE APOSTLES, P. 547

“*"The church of Ephesus had let slip her first love. She was more intent on carrying on the forms and ceremonies of religion than on possessing its spirit. She was more anxious to win the approval of men than to win the approval of God."*

— Ellen G. White

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F — NOTES

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"The Sabbath is God's built-in resistance against becoming Demas."

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F — NOTES



THE SABBATH AS CORRECTIVE

It interrupts. It recenters.

Not a rule. A rescue.

IT INTERRUPTS

- Identity through achievement
- Constant striving
- Replacement of God by good things

IT RECENTERS

- Relationship over performance
- Trust over productivity
- Devotion over deliverables

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F — NOTES



*"Demas still looked connected to ministry,
but his heart had drifted from Jesus.*

*He lost his **first love** before he lost his way."*

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F — NOTES



QR PULSE #3 — OPEN RESPONSE

**"What is competing with Christ for your deepest
affection right now?"**



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Your answer is anonymous — word cloud displays live

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AFTER THE WORD CLOUD

*"I think what we're seeing here...
is that we can become closer to Demas
than we thought."*

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F — NOTES



PRIVATE REFLECTION — 2 MINUTES — NOT FOR SHARING

*"What would it look like to choose Christ first this week? Not in
general. This week."*

Have someone pray for this group and the focus for THIS WEEK.

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F — NOTES



Before we close — a question to carry home:

"If someone wrote one sentence about your spiritual life five years from now — would it sound more like Colossians... or 2 Timothy?"

Colossians 4:14 — co-laborer, present, trusted
2 Timothy 4:10 — having loved this present world

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F — NOTES



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*Close in prayer. Not for success.
Not for productivity.
For reordered love.*

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F — NOTES



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